

[Return to Search](#)

Ecology and culture of the pastoral Tuareg

Author(S): Nicolaisen, Johannes

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 454

Culture (OWC): [Tuareg \(MS25\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1951-1962

Coverage Date: 1800-1963

Place Coverage: Niger And Algeria

Section Title(S): AYR

The Tuareg of Ahaggar and Ayr largely follow the same rules of kinship behaviour. These are outlined below:—

(1) Respect must be shown to all consanguineous relatives of ascending generations, that is respect towards all relatives termed “father”, “mother”, and “mother's brother”.

(2) Respect must be shown to all persons known as “elder brothers” and “elder sisters”. Rules of conduct towards such kinsmen are identical with those mentioned above towards kinsmen of ascending generations. Thus a younger brother on a journey with his elder brother will carry out all work as if he was with his father or another kinsman of ascending generations. When with his elder brother he must not talk about any matter referring to sexual life. He must not even talk too much about the copulation of domestic animals, and he should not mention such words as *imad* and *tindé* — names of musical instruments used at nightly gatherings which may be accompanied by love-making. A man must not ask his elder brother for a gift, but should ask for anything he wants through a third person. When he wishes to marry, the permission of his elder brother should be asked like that of the father and other older relatives. When the father dies the elder brother takes over his position of authority. The identical rules of conduct towards a father (or older relative) and an elder brother can be clearly shown by the following example: — When I lived among the Tuareg I was incorporated in their kinship organization which is the rule for persons who have no relatives among the people they live among. Once I was attached as a younger brother to a man much older than myself. When travelling together among other Tuareg my “elder brother” was occasionally asked: “Are you his father?”, and when replying:— “No, I am his elder brother”, the questioner would sometimes add:— “Now, there is his father”. For classificatory elder brothers (and sisters) the

123
[Observation In Research](#)

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

605
[Cousins](#)

606
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

same rules are valid, even though in this case the "elder brother" may in fact be considerably younger than his "younger brother".

(3) There is a joking relationship (*tehan* in Ahaggar, *adélen* in Ayr) between all true and classificatory cross-cousins. This joking relationship allows free talk about sexual matters, and when cross-cousins tease each other they frequently refer to matters of sexual life, e.g., "You sleep with old slave women!", "You run after women like a donkey-stallion after a mare!" Teasing permits any insolence, even the tearing away of a cross-cousin's veil in public. Insolence always incurs retaliation, and joking frequently gives rise to *tebbillant*, that is a sham-fight. A fight of this kind will normally end with the losing part running away with something belonging to his cousin. He gives this back only if he feels like it, for cross-cousins are allowed to take each other's things. The same type of joking exists between brothers-in-law and sisters-in-law in Ahaggar and in Ayr.

(4) There is avoidance between parents-in-law and children-in-law in the way that a man avoids very strictly his mothers-in-law, a woman very strictly her fathers-in-law. This rule of conduct is valid for all Tuareg of Ahaggar and Ayr. A man should not talk to his mother-in-law, and must never eat in her presence; he will avoid her tent, and if visiting her camp he will live at a distance of about one hundred metres from her. Similar rules hold for a woman and her father-in-law. Avoidance is less strictly observed between a man and his father-in-law, and there is generally very little avoidance between a woman and her daughter-in-law.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)